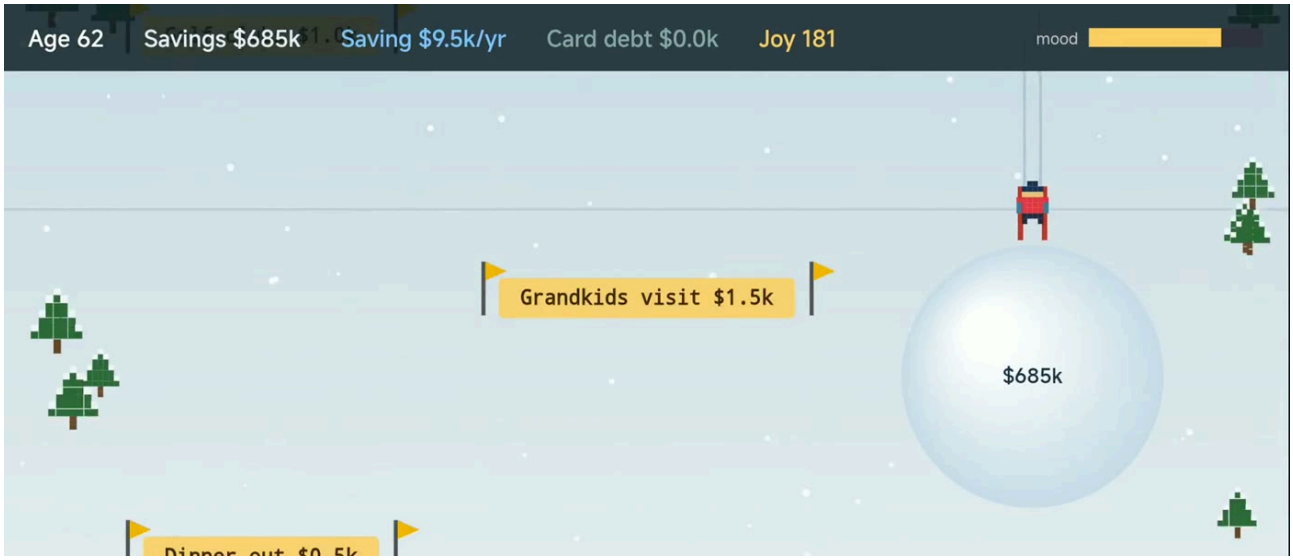
Snowball

Game Concept Document for Zoud GameLab 2026, theme: Make FinLit Fun. Describes build 0.5, the one submitted.

Play in the browser · Arabic edition · 2-minute gameplay video · Game budget (separate document) · Source code



1. Game Overview

Snowball is a skiing game about a whole working life. You ski from age 22 to 67 pushing your savings ahead of you as a snowball. Left alone it grows on its own, treats take a bite out of it, and storms you cannot dodge show why an emergency fund matters.

Title and genre	Snowball (كرة الثلج). Arcade skiing with light money management
Platform	Any browser today, on phone, tablet or computer, by touch, mouse or keyboard. iOS and Android are the next step with funding
Audience	Young adults aged 16 to 30 getting their first salary, and the teachers and programs that want to talk about money with them without a lecture
Length	One life takes about 80 seconds (under 2 minutes at Calm speed), so it fits a class, a commute or a waiting room
Editions	Global ($), UAE (AED) in English, and UAE in Arabic, right to left

What makes it different. The money is a physical thing. The ball is your balance: you watch it grow slowly at 22 and quickly at 60, and you steer it yourself. Because the ball is what touches things, the richer you get, the harder it is to ski around a gold gate. There is no quiz, no menu of choices and no game over. Everyone reaches 67, and then the game prices what your choices cost.

2. Core Gameplay

Objective. Reach 67 with the best life score: joy along the way plus security at the end.

Actions. Steer left and right, by dragging or with the arrow keys. That is the only input, so anyone can play from the first second.

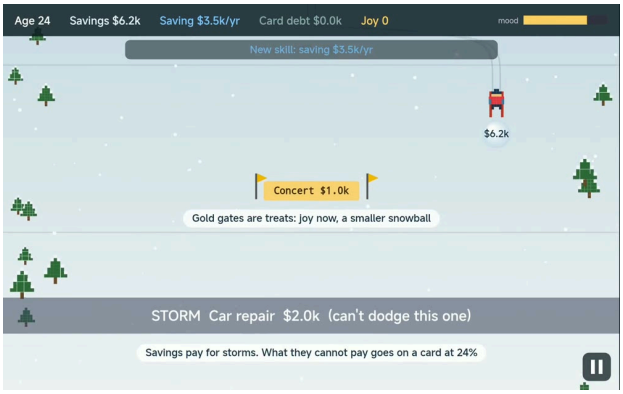
The loop. Every row of the slope is a small decision, and about every 1.5 seconds a year of life goes by.

1. **Gold gates are treats.** Ski through for joy, and the price comes out of the ball. Ski around and you keep the money, but your mood keeps falling.
2. **Blue flags are skills.** Each one raises what you save every year. From age 25 a rarer flag offers an employer match, which is worth three skills.
3. **Storms cross the whole slope** and cannot be dodged. Savings pay for them. What savings cannot cover goes on a credit card.
4. **Every year** savings grow, debt grows, your yearly saving pays the card first, and mood falls.

5. **At 67** you get a score and a receipt: "Your priciest treat: Beach vacation at 37 cost $4.0k then, $23k of money at 67. Same treat at 60: $6.0k."

Decisions and progress. Which treat, and when? Is that flag worth steering past that gate? Four life stages change what tempts you and what hits you: First job (22), Family years (32), Peak earning (47) and Almost there (58). A concert becomes a new car, then a kitchen remodel, then a visit to the grandkids.

Why it is fun to repeat. It is a downhill run with a ball that visibly swells. A life is short, the receipt names something you chose, and "Tap to live it again" is one touch away.



The tutorial is played, not read. The first three rows are one skill, one treat and one storm, each with one line of text, while the slope slows to 40%.

3. Financial Literacy Integration

The game has no lesson screen. Each idea is a rule of the slope, so the player meets it by playing.

Concept	The mechanic	What the player lives through
Compound growth	The ball grows 6% a year by itself	Slow at first, then it swells: $47k at 33 and $685k at 62 in the run in our video
Opportunity cost	A treat leaves the ball, and the receipt prices it in money at 67	A $4k trip at 37 turns out to have been $23k
Emergency fund	Storms cannot be dodged, and savings absorb them	The same $2k car repair is nothing with savings and a problem without them
High-interest debt	The overflow goes on a card at 24%. The card drags the ball, and yearly saving pays it first	Debt is felt in the hands: steering turns slow, and saving stops until the card is gone
Earning and saving more	Blue flags raise yearly saving, and an employer match is free money	A flag taken at 25 keeps paying for 42 years
Balance	Mood falls every year without a treat. At zero you burn out and splurge $3k with no joy	Saving everything is not the answer either
Spending with intent	A treat's joy depends on how worn down you are, not on its price	Sneakers when you are exhausted beat a car when you are fine
Lifestyle creep	The ball touches things first, and it keeps growing	The richer you are, the harder it is to avoid spending
Enough is a goal	Security counts up to a $300k nest egg (about $12k a year at the 4% rule) and nothing past it	"You could have enjoyed more"

The score rewards a plan, not hoarding. Six ways to live, measured with the game's own money model (saving $3k a year, no skills, no storms; pinned in `tests/econ.test.mjs`):

Way of living	Joy	Security	Score
Never treat yourself	0	400	400
A $1k treat every 5 years	193	400	593
A $1k treat every 2 years	340	400	740
A $1k treat every year	538	400	**938**
A $2k treat every year	538	237	775
A $4k treat every year, more than you save	538	−400	138

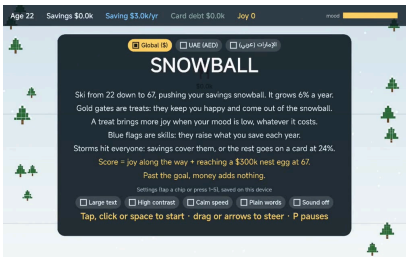
What we hope players understand after playing

1. Money invested early has the most years to grow. Saving $3k a year from 22 ends at $638k and from 32 at $334k: $30k less put in, $304k less at 67.
2. An emergency fund is what keeps a storm from becoming high-interest debt.
3. Card debt grows faster than savings, and it eats the money you meant to save.
4. Enjoying life is part of the plan. Small, well-timed treats give as much joy as big ones, and a late treat costs far less future money than an early one.

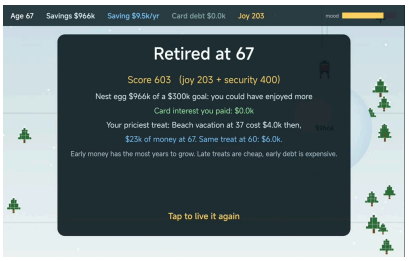
Accuracy. 6% is a long-run average for a diversified index fund, not a promise. 24% is a typical card APR. The model leaves out inflation and taxes so it stays readable, and the game is not financial advice. All of it is one file with no graphics (`econ.js`), with tests that check it teaches true things.

UAE and Arabic edition, built during the jam. Same game, different money. Amounts are in AED at the 3.6725 peg. The snowball sits in a Sharia-compliant fund and earns profit, not interest. Zakat takes 2.5% of what you own once that reaches the nisab (fixed at AED 35k in the game, while the real figure moves with gold). It leaves the ball, but the score counts it at what it would have grown to, so giving never lowers your score, and players it does not apply to can turn it off. The UAE's end-of-service gratuity savings plan replaces the employer match. Cards cost about 3% a month. Treats and storms come from Gulf life: a weekend in Oman, Eid shopping and Eidiya, the rent deposit and agent fee, school fees rising, an AC breakdown in August.

4. Visual Style & Player Experience



Title card: editions and settings



At 67: the score and the receipt



UAE edition in Arabic, right to left

Art direction. A top-down winter slope, seen from above: a pixel-art skier and pines, gold slalom gates, blue flags, falling snow and a ski trail behind you. Everything is drawn in code, with no image files, so the whole game is about 50 KB and loads on a weak connection. The sky turns greyer as your mood falls.

Setting and tone. Calm and forgiving. The skier has no name, gender or nationality, so the life on the slope can be anyone's. Nothing punishes you with a game over, and the final card says what happened without scolding.

Sound. Short synthesized blips (WebAudio, no audio files). The game never depends on them: every sound has a visual twin, a short message with the same fact in a colour that also carries the meaning.

Interface. One bar at the top shows age, savings, yearly saving, card debt, joy and mood. Treats, skills and storms differ by shape and text, not only by colour.

Accessibility, on the title and pause cards and saved on the device. Large text (30% bigger), high contrast, Calm speed (30% slower, with the same money lessons), plain words ("card debt" becomes "borrowed"), and sound off. Keyboard, mouse and touch all play the whole game. Pausing stops everything, so the game can be read at any pace. A teacher can share the settings with a class by link.

5. Development & Future Plans

In the prototype today. A full life from 22 to 67 with four stages, gates, flags, storms, card debt, mood and burnout. A played tutorial, the score and the receipt. Three editions, five accessibility settings, pause and sound. Automated tests for the money model, the editions and the accessibility settings.

Not done yet. The art and sound are prototype level, drawn and synthesized in code. No real learners have played it in a study. The Arabic was drafted with AI and checked in the game on a real device, but no native speaker has reviewed it. It runs only in the browser, and there are no teacher tools.

Priorities, in order

The plan is six months and 1,000 hours, and the budget shows what ships at each funding level.

1. Review of the Arabic and of the zakat and Sharia framing by a native speaker and an Islamic-finance adviser.
2. Three rounds of playtests with learners aged 16 to 30, with before-and-after questions on the four lessons above.
3. Classroom mode: a teacher view with no personal data, a 10-minute lesson plan and a printable debrief.
4. iOS and Android release, tested on low-end phones.
5. More life events and three life paths, original art (including desert and city slopes) and original music.

Risks, and what we do about them

Risk	Our answer
Players enjoy it but do not learn	Before-and-after questions from the first playtest, a playtest report, and design changes if the answers do not move
A short run gets repetitive	More life events, life paths and slope themes come after the learning is proven
An error of fact or culture in the UAE edition	Reviewed before any release outside the jam. The rules live in one file with its own tests
Our record is apps, not games	Art and sound go to specialists, and every stage is checked with players

Reaching players and paying for itself. Players never pay: the web version stays free, with no ads and no data collected from them. Schools, banks, employers and public programs already pay for financial education, and they are who can sustain it, by licensing classroom mode and co-branded editions in their own currency, products and language. A new edition is mostly one data file (`region.js`), so adding a market stays cheap. We start in the UAE, where the edition already exists, and our other products already ship in Spanish and Portuguese, which are natural next editions. We have no customers or partners yet. Those conversations start once classroom mode exists.

6. Your Team

Alan De Bortolo, Design Master Solutions LLC (Massachusetts, USA). Solo entry: game design, the numbers, testing and production. The code and the first draft of the Arabic were written with an AI assistant (Claude), as stated on the game's page. The design, the balance, the numbers and the tests on real devices are ours.

Relevant experience. The studio designs, codes, hosts and supports its own software products (Stone Project is live on iOS, Android, Mac, Windows and the web) and builds iOS and Android apps for clients, so store releases, support and localization are everyday work. Alan also builds LAPI, a personal and family finance app in Brazil (lapiapp.com), so how people really handle money is familiar ground.

Support we would bring in. A native Arabic speaker and an Islamic-finance adviser, a pixel artist, a composer, and teachers to shape classroom mode. All of it is in the budget.